



▲ HAUTE CUISINE

The Armani/Caffè at Jio World Plaza, Mumbai, which also boasts of other luxury brands like Louis Vuitton

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Then comes the influence of social media. Over the years, all luxury brands have started seeking the help of influencers to get their product and heritage across the world. Since luxury is not merely the craftsmanship or price tags, the very fact that it can make a social statement thereby also creating a social acceptance has also paved the way for the increase in demand.

While the country is seeing an expansion of purchasing power and retail space, European luxury associations are keenly watching these developments. According to Armando Branchini, Honorary Executive Director of Milan-based Fondazione Altagamma, the association of Italian luxury brands, the increase in retail space will be welcomed by the European luxury community. "To successfully do business of luxury we need reliable partners, and we have that in Reliance Brands, Aditya Birla Fashion Retail Ltd and individuals such as Ashok and Reena Wadhwa who have brought in Gucci, Saint Laurent, etc.," says Branchini. "Then comes the infrastructure. Once that develops it becomes even more pleasurable to do business in India."

Branchini says India is being looked at as a very promising market, especially with the slowing of the Chinese economy. That is echoed by the association of French luxury brands, Comité Colbert. "Many of our French luxury maisons are now considering India with interest, despite obstacles that remain like the lack of infrastructure or the level of import duties," says its President & CEO Bénédicte Epinay.



"Post Covid, even Tier II cities have witnessed an increase in wealthy people and their aggregate number will create substantial demand for high end consumer products"

ANSHUMAN MAGAZINE

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Malls dedicated to luxury brands are especially important in India as there is very little possibility of developing high streets such as Monte Napoleone in Milan, Fifth Avenue in New York, Avenue Montaigne in Paris or Sloane Street in London due to factors like weather and space. "With each mall being launched or expanded more cohorts of consumers, who otherwise indulged elsewhere, or bought other brands, are bound to become consumers for the brands that come with these new malls. And malls on their side, be it the DLF, Phoenix or Nexus-Blackstone, plan to open newer retail facilities where the concentration of wealth is seen and wherever they go, we will also go along and launch our brands there," says the RBL spokesperson.

That means good news for the luxury shopper in India. The battle of the luxury malls is just getting started. **BT**

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